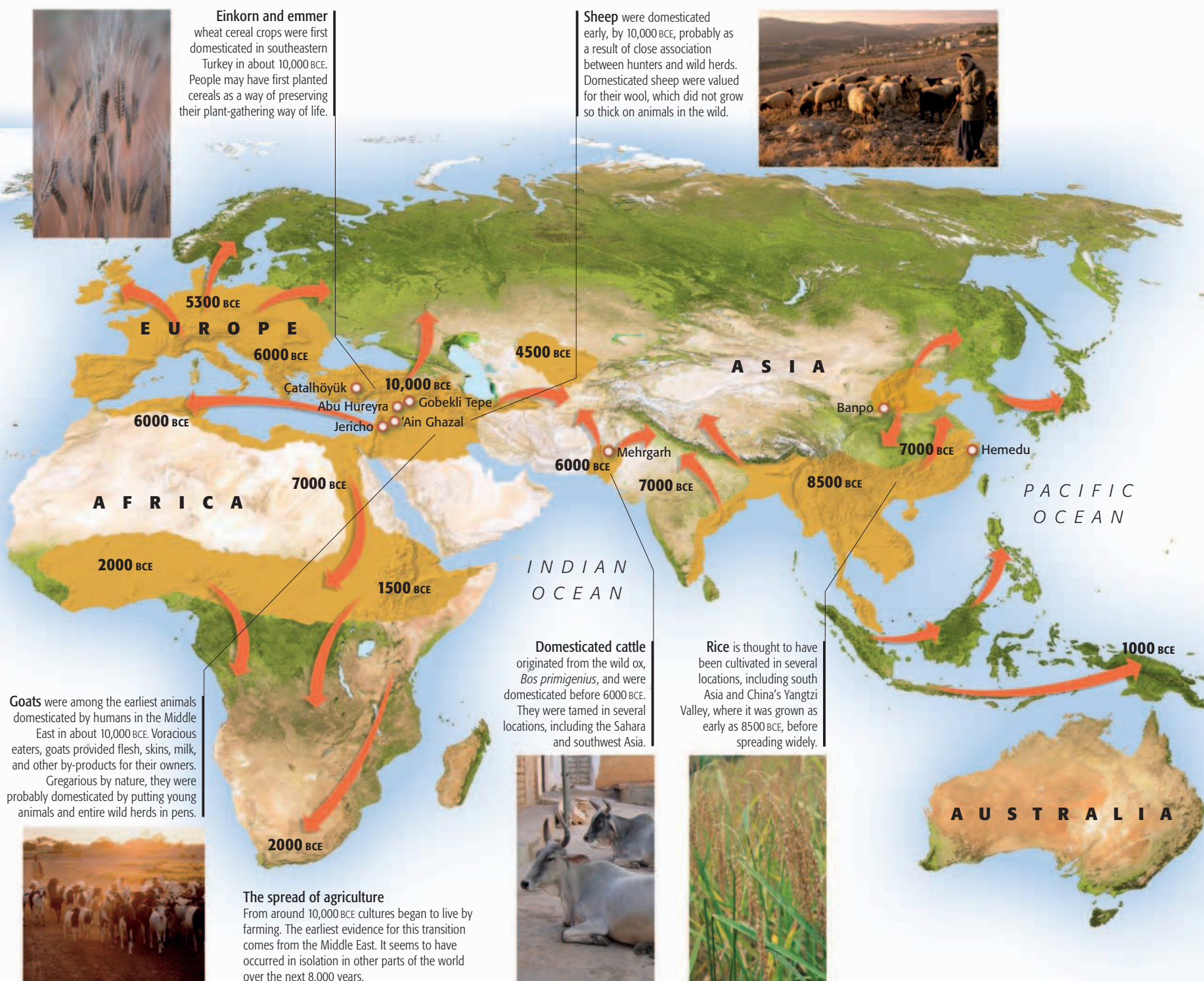




of the north (see p.60), which practiced an early form of irrigation, was thriving by 5000 BCE.

First European farmers

Farming spread to Europe from southwest Asia by about 6000 BCE. It expanded across the Mediterranean, then northward, developing with slight variations in the associated crafts and architectural style as it spread.

Farming the Americas

The ancient native American population developed an expertise with wild plants. By 4000 BCE, many hunter-gatherer groups in the Americas were

growing sunflowers and other native plants as part of their vegetable diet. In the Andes Mountains in South America, hunters experimented with the cultivation of potatoes and other indigenous root vegetables.

The staple crops of native American agriculture—corn and beans—were both domesticated in Central America by 3500 BCE. Corn was domesticated from teosinte, a grass native to Central America. Many varieties developed. From the tropics, this vital staple spread to the Andes and into the North American southwest by 2500 BCE, before coming into use later in eastern North America.

Farming has had huge and far-reaching social effects beyond changing what humans eat.

GROWTH OF VILLAGES AND TOWNS

Food production tied people to cultivated land and grazing grounds, giving rise to **permanent settlements 38–39 >>**.

TIME TO INNOVATE

Not everyone was needed in order to produce enough food to feed the community. **Individuals began to specialize** in a particular trade, such as pottery and metalwork **42–43 >>**. Farming

produced surplus food. This was stored for times of need or traded, creating new trading possibilities. **Farming fed more people** within smaller areas, promoting **growth in population**.

GETTING MORE OUT

As populations increased, so did the **pressure on the land**. If favorable areas could not be sought out, **new techniques** had to be developed, such as the **irrigation systems** used in Egypt. The pressure on food production and the desire to produce more has continued to this day **290–91, 462–63 >>**.